

Samantha Cervantes

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EDUCATION

Ph.D., Public Administration	2022 – 2027 (expected)
Maxwell School, Syracuse University	
<i>Fields:</i> Education Policy and Urban Economics	
<i>Advisors:</i> Amy Ellen Schwartz and Michah W. Rothbart	
M.S., Applied Economics with Honors	2022
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	
Certificate in Applied Statistics	2019
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	
B.A., Business Administration, minor in Political Science	2018
Instituto Tecnológico Autónomo de México (ITAM), Mexico City, Mexico	

RESEARCH INTERESTS

Urban Policy, Education Policy, Neighborhood Effects, Economics of Crime

RESEARCH

Job Market Paper

The Intended and Unintended Impacts of a Crime-Deterrence Experiment on Academic Outcomes: Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights

with Amy Ellen Schwartz

Place-based public-safety interventions are typically evaluated by whether they reduce crime, while their broader effects on residents, including those of children, remain understudied. We study this question using a randomized crime-deterrence experiment that installed 600,000-lumen light towers in public housing developments, reducing neighborhood crime (Mitre-Becerril et al., 2022) but potentially generating negative externalities related to the light intruding into students' residences. We link the experimental data to administrative records of public school students, incident-level crime and arrest data, building and development characteristics to estimate effects on students' crime exposure and academic outcomes. Students in developments assigned a higher lighting dose experienced large reductions in nighttime and daytime index crime, arrests, and incidents involving underage victims, but achievement did not improve on average. We use building height as a proxy for otherwise unobserved residential light intrusion. Students in taller buildings gained in achievement and attendance, while students in shorter buildings lost 0.22 standard deviations in math, roughly twice the size of the gains among students in taller buildings. The math loss and height contrast are not explained by differential crime reductions or schooling and are absent among students living just outside the developments. Consistent with sleep disruption, effects emerge earlier for girls than for boys, are accompanied by sharp increases in overweight risk among girls, and are modestly larger on noisier streets. The findings show that the built environment shaped which channel—safety gains or residential light intrusion—dominated the intervention's effects on students.

WORKING PAPERS

Hold Harmless for Whom? The Impact of COVID Era Policies for School Funding, Teachers, and Students. (R&R at *Education Finance and Policy*)

with Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz

How a Good School in the Neighborhood Affects Academic Outcomes, with Sarah Cordes, Jeehee Han, and Amy Ellen Schwartz

WORKS IN PROGRESS

The Impact of a Crime Deterrence Intervention on Political Behavior, with Ying Shi

Housing Market Responses to Salient Police Interventions: Experimental Evidence from High-Intensity Streetlights, with Alexander Cardazzi

The Long-Term Impacts of Neighborhood Violence on Youth Outcomes, with Amy Ellen Schwartz

PRE-DOCTORAL RESEARCH

The Effect of Public Transit Expansions on Crime: Evidence from Mexico City

RESEARCH AND PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Graduate Research Associate, Center for Policy Research 2022 –
Professors Michah W. Rothbart and Amy Ellen Schwartz, Syracuse University

Research Assistant, Center for Competitiveness Studies 2019 – 2022
Professor Guillermo Abdel Musik, ITAM

Investment Consultant, Profuturo Pensiones 2018 – 2019
Mexico City, Mexico

TEACHING

Syracuse University, MPA Program

Fall 2026 Economics for Public Decisions

Spr 2025 Education Policy, Quantitative Analysis (Guest Lecturer)

Spr 2024, 2025 Quantitative Analysis

2023, 2024 Public Budgeting (Intensive Summer Courses)

Fall 2022 Public Budgeting

PRESENTATIONS

Scheduled NYU Furman Center; Southern Economics Association (SEA); ViCE seminar

2026 Urban Economics Association (UEA); American Real Estate and Urban Economics Association (AREUEA); FLX Economics of Education Workshop; Capital District Applied Microeconomics Workshop; Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP)

2025	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)
2024	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM); Association for Education Finance and Policy (AEFP); Public Finance and Budgeting Northeastern Workshop
2023	Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management (APPAM)

GRANTS & AWARDS

First Place, Graduate Student Poster-Session	2026
Center for Policy Research, Syracuse University	
Summer Dissertation Fellowship	
Syracuse University	
Ph.D. Department Research Grant	2025
Syracuse University	
Financial Inclusion Essay Award	2021
National Banking and Securities Commission, Mexico City, Mexico	

SERVICE

Graduate Student Representative, Center for Policy Research	2026 – 2027
Maxwell School, Syracuse University	
Referee: <i>Educational Researcher, Journal of Behavioral Public Administration</i>	

SKILLS

Software: Stata, R, QGIS, Python

Languages: English (fluent), Spanish (native)

REFERENCES

Amy Ellen Schwartz, Professor Emerita of Economics

aeschwar@udel.edu

Michah W. Rothbart, Associate Professor of Public Administration

mwrothba@syr.edu

Ying Shi, Associate Professor of Public Administration

yshi78@syr.edu